

other media players don't have; it's something like a volume control for the equaliser. When you turn it right up, all the frequencies you control using the equaliser are pumped up, and the effect of sliding a particular frequency up or down will be more pronounced. Another setting you might not know about is the "Auto" button: when you do a trial and error and come upon a setting that's perfect for a particular song, select Presets > Save > Auto-load preset... The next time that song plays, the equaliser settings you chose to Auto-load will, well, automatically load.

When you right-click anywhere in Winamp (except on a song in a playlist), you'll come across Options > Preferences. There's a ton—and we mean a ton—of options here, probably more than in other media players. For example, one setting you won't see in other players is "Priority class"—the higher this setting, the more the CPU power Winamp will use. Keep it at Idle or Normal for most purposes; if you have a slow computer, and opening a document makes a track "skip," you might want to change it to High. (Track skipping is audible as a small break in the playback.) "Realtime" is not recommended unless your tracks keep skipping all the time.

Under Plug-ins > Input, look at Nullsoft MPEG Audio Decoder 3.5. This is what decodes your MP3s so Winamp can play them. The first tab lists "Full file buffering"; set this to a high value if you want your MP3s to be placed entirely in RAM and play from there. This setting is useful if you have a lot of RAM. Then there's the option between logarithmic and linear for the equaliser. "Logarithmic" (the default) is the opposite of "exponential," and means that increasing a certain frequency boosts it by just a reasonable amount. Setting it to "linear" will enable more drastic playing around with the equaliser settings—setting a particular control higher will make more of a difference than if it's set to logarithmic.

Winamp, like Windows Media Player and RealPlayer, has an inbuilt Media Library that holds all your music. Rather, it keeps track of your collection. From the menu on the left, you can book-